



PANAMA

Capital city: Panama City
Area: 30,193 sq miles (78,200 sq km)
Population: 3,100,000
Official language: Spanish
Major religions: Christian 92%, Jewish and other 8%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: Balboa
Adult literacy rate: 92%
Life expectancy: 75 years
People per doctor: 588
Televisions: 187 per 1,000 people

PANAMA

THE COUNTRY OF PANAMA forms a land link between the North and South American continents. The Panama Canal, which cuts through the country and joins the Atlantic and Pacific oceans, is a vital link in international sea trade. Panama has a hot, steamy climate with heavy rainfall, especially on its Caribbean coast. The interior is mountainous. The best farmland is in the lowlands on the Pacific coast, where the main cash crops, bananas, coffee, and sugar, are grown. Shrimps, caught in the coastal waters, are also an important export.



FROM OCEAN TO OCEAN

There is an 85-ft (26-m) difference in height between Gatun Lake and the two oceans. From the Atlantic, ships are raised up through the Gatun locks (1, 2, and 3). Then they are lowered via the Pedro Miguel locks (4) and, finally, through the Miraflores locks (5 and 6) into the Pacific.



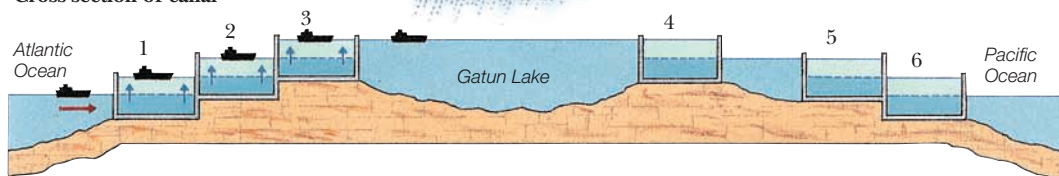
PANAMA CANAL

Every year some 14,000 ships negotiate the locks of the Panama Canal. First opened in 1914, the canal is 51 miles (82 km) long, with a minimum depth of 39 ft (12 m). Forty thousand workers, mostly from the Caribbean, worked on the canal, which took 10 years to build and cost \$US380 million. It also cost thousands of lives. After sharing the canal with the US for many years, Panama took complete control of the canal in December 1999.



Banks and business centers line the canal approach to Panama City.

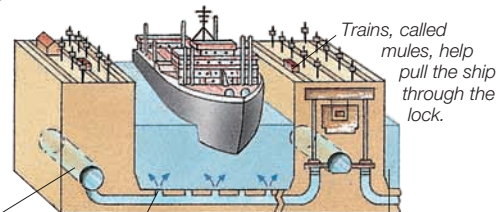
Cross-section of canal



Nine months of tropical rain each year keeps Gatun Lake full. Water from the lake feeds the locks.

Detail of lock chamber

A ship waits in a lock chamber while water is piped in to lift the ship to the next level.



Water is fed through huge pipes, called culverts, down the sides of the lock.

Ships travel in the opposite direction along this channel.

A series of smaller pipes feeds water into the lock from the culverts.

CANAL AT THE CROSSROADS

The canal puts Panama at the crossroads of international trade. Revenue from the canal, and from the Free Trade Zone at its mouth in Colón, is vital to the economy. Since 1970, Panama has been one of the world's main financial centers, and its tax-free banking attracts investors from around the world.

CUNA INDIANS

The original inhabitants of Panama were mostly Cuna, Guaymí, and Choco Indians, but their numbers were severely reduced after the arrival of European explorers in the 16th century. The Cuna once held considerable power in the area and traded, mainly by canoe, along the Caribbean coast. Important chiefs were carried by hammock. Today, the Cuna live in small villages and depend on agriculture for a living.



Hammocks are made of woven fiber from plants that grow on the coast.

Embroidered clothing designs, known as molas, are a feature of the Cuna culture.

THE GOOD SOIL

Panama has many rivers. The soil that develops from clays, sand, and silt deposited from these rivers is called alluvial soil, and is good for growing crops such as the vegetables shown here. With poorer soils the land is used for a few years and then left until its natural fertility returns. This system of land use is called *roza*.



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